The Three Characteristics
(Ti-lakkhana)

Impermanence	(Anicca)
Suffering / Unsatisfactoriness	(Dukkha) see Four Noble Truths
No-self	(Anatta) see Five Aggregates

These three characteristics are shared by all phenomena. They describe the nature of reality:
Everything is impermanent, subject to change, unstable.
The characteristics of suffering and no-self stem from this impermanence. Any object or mind state is inherently unsatisfying by virtue of its being impermanent, and clinging to it will cause suffering.
The sense of self is a product of changing physical conditions and impermanent mental states, (see Five Aggregates) and does not inherently exist. Our liberation or our bondage depends on realizing the Three Characteristics inherent in every experience or being ignorant of them. If it is clearly and deeply seen that all objects and mind states are impermanent, unsatisfactory and without selfhood, one sees that there is nothing worth clinging to, which leads to liberation and the end of suffering.

When the Three Characteristics are not seen, this delusion leads to greed and aversion, which are the Three Unwholesome Roots.

The Three Unwholesome Roots
(Akusala Mula)

Greed (Lobha, attraction to what is pleasant)
Aversion (Dosa, resistance to what is unpleasant)
Delusion (Moha, not seeing the Three Characteristics)

The Three Unwholesome Roots are those negative mental factors which are the source of attitudes and behaviors that result in suffering. Greed and aversion arise from, and perpetuate, delusion.
Delusion means not perceiving the Three Characteristics. When we do not realize that all things are impermanent, unsatisfactory, and without selfhood, we relate to them with greed and aversion, which prevents us from seeing their true nature.

Driven by greed, we fight against impermanence (Anicca), increasing our suffering (Dukkha) and our aversion to it, all because delusion produces the perception of a seperate self (not understanding Anatta).

The Five Aggregates
(Pañcakkhandha)

Body, form	(Rūpa)
Feeling	(Vedanā)
Perceptions / memory	(Saññā)
Mental Formations	(Sankhāra)
Consciousness	(Viññāna)

The Five Aggregates are those categories of phenomena which we cling to as me or mine.

The first aggregate (rūpa) includes the body, the senses and tangible objects. Feeling (vedanā) refers to the pleasant, unpleasant or neutral quality present in each moment of experience. Perception (saññā) is of six kinds (relating to the six senses): perception of form, sound, smell, taste, bodily impressions and mental impressions. Mental formations (sankhāra) are the psychological elements of experience, including thoughts, emotions, volition, and habitual patterns. Consciousness (viññāna) is of six types (relating to the six senses): eye-consciousness, ear-consciousness, olfactory consciousness, taste consciousness, tactile consciousness, and consciousness of mental objects.

The Five Aggregates influence and condition each other, arising and combining together to form our experience of self and the world. The body and senses receive impressions, and feelings arise together with associative recognitions (memory) and perceptions, all colored by mental formations (thoughts, emotions, etc.), the entire process taking place with varying degrees of Consciousness. (See Dependent Co-Arising.)

The interaction of and identification with the Five Aggregates produces the sense of a separate, inherently existing self which is under the influence of the Three Unwholesome Roots. Our experience of the "external" world is also a product of these Five Aggregates. There is nothing that we experience that is outside of these Five Aggregates.

The Three Characteristics describe how things are (external and internal reality).
The Three Unwholesome Roots are the negative mental influences preventing insight.
The Five Aggregates are those factors which produce the experience of self and the world.

The Five Aggregates are under the influence of the
Three Unwholesome Roots and the Three Characteristics are not seen.
These are the givens of the human situation.

The Four Noble Truths
(Cattari Ariya Sacca)

1. There is suffering. (Dukkha, one of the Three Characteristics)
2. Suffering has a cause. (Samudaya, explained as Dependent Co-Arising)
3. It is possible to end suffering. (Nirodha)
4. The path leading to the end of suffering. (Magga, explained as the Noble Eightfold Path)

The Four Noble Truths are the Buddha's description of, and prescription for, the human condition.

1. There is suffering (Dukkha, one of the Three Characteristics)
The changing conditions of life are incapable of providing lasting satisfaction.
The action of and the attachment to the Five Aggregates are suffering.

2. Suffering has a cause. (Samudaya, see Dependent Co-Arising.)
The cause of suffering is craving (tanhā)
The three main categories of craving are:
desire for sense pleasures (kāma-tanhā).
desire for existence (bhava-tanhā).
desire for non-existence (vibhava-tanhā).

3. It is possible to end suffering. (Nirodha)
When craving ceases, suffering ceases.

4. The path leading to the end of suffering. (Magga, explained as The Noble Eightfold Path)
What it is understood that craving always results in suffering,
one seeks to eliminate craving. This is accomplished by following

The Noble Eightfold Path:

Right View, Right Intention, Right Speech, Right Action,
Right Livelihood, Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, Right Concentration.

To become enlightened and liberated, one must gain insight into the Three Characteristics,
The Four Noble Truths focus on the characteristic of suffering,
since that characteristic is most noticeable and problematic.

Dependent Co-Arising
(Paticcasamuppāda)

Past Causes	1. Ignorance	(Avijjā, one of the Three Unwholesome Roots)
	2. Volition	(Sankhāra, one of the Five Aggregates)
Present Results	3. Consciousness	(Viññāna, one of the 5A)
	4. Body and Mind	(Nāma-rūpa, one of the 5A)
	5. Senses	(Āyatana)
	6. Contact	(Phassa)
	7. Feeling	(Vedanā, one of the 5A)
Present Causes	8. Craving	(Tanhā, the second Noble Truth)
	9. Grasping	(Upadānā)
	10. Becoming	(Bhava)
Future Results	11. Birth	(Jāti)
	12. Aging, Death	(Jarā-marana)

Dependent Co-Arising (the details of the second Noble Truth) describes the cycling of the perceived self (the Five Aggregates) in samsara (unsatisfactory existence), each link leading to and conditioning the next. It is used to show how one existence leads to another (rebirth).
Present results (3-7) are experienced in this life because of past causes (1-2). Present causes (8-10) are actions is this life which will shape the next existence (11,12).

More importantly, Dependent Co-Arising applies to the psychological process moment to moment. It shows how the Five Aggregates interact and are conditioned by each other:
Ignorance (1), conditions volition (2), which shapes consciousness (3), conditioning body and mind (4), which includes the senses (5), which interact with the world (6), causing feelings to arise (7) to which we react (often unskillfully, 8-9), resulting in the suffering of hope and fear (10), leading to birth and death (11,12).

If the arising of feeling (7) is accompanied by mindfull awareness (see second Contemplation of Mindfulness), the tendency toward liking and disliking (craving) can be broken and liberation realized. The constant flux of elements and factors in Dependent Co-Arising also illustrates the truth of emptiness (lack of any substantial entity in the process).

The Noble Eightfold Path
(Ariya Atthangika Magga)

Wisdom	(Paññā)
1. Right View	(Sammā-ditthi)
2. Right Intention	(Sammā-sankappa)
Morality	**(Sīla)**
3. Right Speech	(Sammā-vācā)
4. Right Action	(Sammā-kammanta)
5. Right Livelihood	(Sammā-ājīva)
Concentration	**(Samādhi)**
6. Right Effort	(Sammā-vāyāma)
7. Right Mindfulness	(Sammā-sati)
8. Right Concentration	(Sammā-samādhi)

The Noble Eightfold Path, being the fourth of The Four Noble Truths, is the practice that leads to enlightenment.
The path has eight aspects, grouped under three headings:
Morality (Sīla), Concentration (Samādhi), and Wisdom (Paññā).

Right View is the perspective provided by understanding The Four Noble Truths
Right Intention is freedom from sense desire, (lust), and cruelty.
Right Speech refrains from lying, gossip, harsh speech and idle chatter.
Right Action refrains from killing, stealing and adultery.
Right Livelihood prohibits dealing in arms, poisons, hunting, usury, etc.
Right Effort restrains and abandons negative mental states,
while developing and preserving positive mental states.
Right Mindfulness is explained as the Four Foundations of Mindfulness.
Right Concentration is the focusing of the mind associated with wholesome consciousness.
In its highly developed stages, concentration is experienced as eight levels of increasing subtlety called the Jhānas. These refined states of concentration cannot in themselves result in liberation, but their development provides a tranquillity and sharpness of mind that can aid in the realization of the nature of reality.

All aspects of The Noble Eightfold Path support and reinforce each other, providing a stable basis for the cultivation of insight.

The Four Foundations of Mindfulness
(Satipatthāna)

Body	(Kāya)
Feeling	(Vedanā)
Mind States	(Citta)
Mind Objects (Dhamma)	

The Four Foundations of Mindfulness (7th aspect of NEP) are the categories of experience to be investigated with awareness in order to realize the impermanent, unsatisfactory, and impersonal nature of existence.
The Four Foundations of Mindfulness could be seen as a regrouping of the Five Aggregates, emphasizing those aspects and ways of looking at them that are most conducive to insight and liberation.

I. Contemplation of the body (Kāyānupassanā, contemplation of the first Aggregate)
Attention is focused and established on bodily phenomena.
Mindfulness of the body has six aspects:

Breathing	(Anāpānasati)
Postures	(Iriyāpatha)
Clear Comprehension	(Sampajañña/Pāli) Mindfulness of movements & actions.
32 Parts of the Body	(Kāyagatāsati)
Material Elements	(Dhātuvavatthāna) Mindfulness of solidity, fluidity, heat and movement within the body.
Cemetery Contemplations (Sivathika)	Mindfulness of bodily decay.

II. Contemplation of Feeling (Vedanānupassanā, contemplation of the second Aggregate)
Attention is focused and established on the pleasant, unpleasant or neutral feeling that arises following sensory contact. The instruction here is to be aware of how these feelings arise and how they dissolve. Feelings here refers not to emotion, but to the bare experience of pleasant, unpleasant or neutral sensation, physical or mental. Feeling is investigated because it conditions craving and continued suffering (see 7-8). It is an element of experience with which we identify strongly and the degree of mindfulness of feelings determines whether we will be swept away by them or not.

III. Contemplation of Mind (Cittānupassanā, contemplation of the fifth Aggregate)
Attention is focused and established on mind states (hatred, ignorance, distraction, concentration, etc). The instruction here is to be aware of the presence or absence of mind states and of their arising and dissolution. Mind states are focused on so that we may see how they color perception, rather than identifying with them as reality.

IV. Contemplation of Mind Objects (Dhammānupassanā, contemplation of the third & fourth Aggregate)
One focuses and establishes attention on mind objects. Attention is focused on those factors that should be investigated to facilitate meditation and lead to wisdom.

The Five Hindrances - which block understanding, hindering meditation and insight.
The Five Aggregates - which make up the sense of self.
The Six Senses - which can lead to craving.
The Four Noble Truths - those mental factors to be cultivated.
- seeing things in terms of the truth of suffering, its cause and its end.

1. The Five Hindrances (Nīvarana)

Sense desire	(Kāmacchanda)
Aversion	(Vyāpāda)
Sloth & Torpor	(Thīna-middha)
Restlessness & Worry	(Uddhacca-kukkucca)
Doubt	(Vicikicchā)

The Five Hindrances are those mental factors that hinder meditation (concentration and insight).
The instruction here is to be aware of the presence or absence of the hindrances,
how they arise, how they disappear, and how they are abandoned.
When we are swept away by them, the Five Hindrances prevent tranquillity and clarity.
When we investigate them with mindfulness, they can be overcome.

2. The Five Aggregates (Pañcakkhandha)
We investigate them as those aspects of experience which we cling to as self. The instruction here is to be aware of the nature of the aggregates, how they arise, and how they disappear.

3. The Six Internal and External Sense Bases (Āyatana, 5th link in Dependent Co-Arising)

Eye and Visual Objects	(Cakkhu / Rūpa)
Ear and Sounds	(Sota / Sadda)
Nose and Smells	(Ghāna / Gandha)
Tongue and Flavors	(Jivhā / Rasa)
Body and Tangible Objects	(Kāya / Photthabba)
Mind and Mental Objects	(Manāyatana / Dhammāyatana)

The Six Internal and External Sense Bases are the five senses plus the mind along with their respective fields of perception. The meeting of the eye and visual objects conditions the arising of visual consciousness; these three together constitute contact (the sixth link in 12). It is the same for the other senses and the mind.
The instruction concerning this mind object is to be aware of the sense organ and its corresponding object, and the bond of attachment that arises dependent on both (see Dependent Co-Arising). Also, to be aware of how this attachment arises, and how it disappears, and how it is abandoned in the future. The Six Senses are given attention and awareness because they are the basis of all mental activity and this is where we can begin to bring mindfulness to the process described in Dependent Co-Arising. Whereas the second foundation of mindfulness focuses on feeling (the 7th link in 12), here we look at the Six Senses (the 5th link in 12) to investigate the process that conditions contact and feeling.

4. The Seven Factors of Enlightenment (Bojjhanga)

Mindfulness	(Sati, 7th aspect of The Noble Eightfold Path)
Investigation	(Dhammavicaya)
Energy	(Vīrya, 6th aspect of The Noble Eightfold Path)
Rapture	(Pīti)
Calm	(Passaddhi)
Concentration	(Samādhi, 8th aspect of The Noble Eightfold Path)
Equanimity	(Upekkhā, the tenth Perfection)

The seven Factors of Enlightenment are those mental factors that, when brought to perfection and balance, lead to enlightenment. Established in strong and firm mindfulness, one investigates bodily and mental phenomena with persistant energy; there arises rapture (both as physical sensation and mental interest) and the mind becomes calm, which enhances concentration; all of these states and phenomena are viewed with equanimity.

The instruction concerning this mind object is to be aware of the presence or absence of the factors of enlightenment, how the factors arise and how the factors come to be perfected.

5. The Four Noble Truths
To know "This is Dukkha"...
To know "This is the origin of Dukkha"...
To know "This is the cessation of Dukkha"...
To know "This is the path leading to the cessation of Dukkha",
according to the reality of the present moment.

The instruction here is to be aware of experience in the light of The Four Noble Truths regarding suffering (Dukkha); to be aware of what is the path and what is not the path.

The Thirty Seven Requisites of Enlightenment
(Bodhipaakkhiya-dhammā)

The 37 Requisites of Enlightenment are those practices that are conducive to insight and liberation.
In seven overlapping groups, they are a restatement of the factors essential for a successful spiritual practice culminating in liberation.

The Four Foundations of Mindfulness (Satipatthana)
provides the primary methods for the cultivation of insight.

The Four Right Efforts (Samma-ppadhana)
Restraint (Samvara), & Abandonment (Pahana) of unwholesome states;
Development (Bhavana), & Preservation (Anukkhana) of wholesome states,
providing positive mind states and the energy necessary for the cultivation of insight.

The Four Bases of Power (Iddhi-pada)

Interest	(Chanda)
Energy	(Vīrya)
Clear Mind	(Citta)
Investigation	(Vimaṁsa)

Interest, or aspiration, is the desire to attain liberation.
Energy is perseverance in applying The Four Right Efforts.
Clear Mind is clarity of consciousness.
Investigation is examination of phenomena, arising and ceasing.
The Four Bases of Power, also called The Four Roads to Success,
are factors which must be present and developed in order to succeed in attaining liberation.

The Five Faculties (Indriya)

Faith	(Saddha)
Energy	(Vīrya)
Mindfulness	(Sati)
Concentration	(Samadhi)
Wisdom	(Paññā)

Faith - the confidence developed by meditation.
Energy - the factor of effort.
Mindfulness - awareness of what is present.
Concentration - the ability to sustain attention.
Wisdom - seeing the nature of reality, and acting in accord with it.

It is the exercising of these faculties that gives the ability to progress.
Their development and wise application can defeat the Five Hindrances.
When the Five Faculties are developed and strengthened,
they become the Five Powers, incapable of being overcome.

The Five Powers	(Bala)
Faith	(Saddha Balam)
Energy	(Vīrya Balam)
Mindfulness	(Sati Balam)
Concentration	(Samadhi Balam)
Wisdom	(Paññā Balam)

(Boghanga)

Mindfulness	(Sati)
Investigation	(Dhammavicaya)
Energy	(Vīrya)
Rapture	(Pīti)
Calm	(Passaddhi)
Concentration	(Samādhi)
Equanimity	(Upekkhā)

The Seven Factors of Enlightenment are those mental factors which incline the mind toward insight.

The Noble Eightfold Path (Magga)

1. Right View	(Sammā-ditthi)
2. Right Intention	(Sammā-sankappa)
3. Right Speech	(Sammā-vācā)
4. Right Action	(Sammā-kammanta)
5. Right Livelihood	(Sammā-ājīva)
6. Right Effort	(Sammā-vāyāma)
7. Right Mindfulness	(Sammā-sati)
8. Right Concentration	(Sammā-samādhi)

The Noble Eightfold Path is the path that leads to insight, enlightenment, and the end of suffering.

Practicing the Four Foundations of Mindfulness one applies the Four Right Efforts, using the Four Bases of Power as a basis, exercising the Five Faculties and the Five Powers, developing the Seven Factors of Enlightenment all in pursuit of The Noble Eightfold Path.

The Ten Perfections (Paramī)
Generosity (Dāna) - sharing with others.
Morality (Sīla) - purity in speech, action, livelihood.
Renunciation (Nekkhamma) - abandoning sensual desires.
Wisdom (Paññā) - insight into the Three Characteristics.
Energy (Vīrya) - exertion in mental development.
Patience (Khanti) - forbearance.
Truthfulness (Sacca) - acting and speaking in accord with truth.
Resolution (Adhitthana) - determination in following aspiration.
Loving-kindness (Mettā) - benevolence.
Equanimity (Upekkhā) - even-mindedness toward phenomena.
The Ten Perfections are ten qualities of mind and behavior that lead to enlightenment. We can develop these qualities as a basis for responding to the world. The Ten Perfections can be brought to maturity by cultivating the Four Divine Abodes.

The Four Divine Abodes (Brahma Vihara)
Loving-kindness (Mettā) - benevolence towards others.
Compassion (Karunā) - motivation to relieve the suffering of others.
Sympathetic Joy (Muditā) - happiness at other's good fortune.
Equanimity (Upekkhā) - undisturbed by phenomena.
The Four Divine Abodes are those unbounded states of mind that can be developed as the foundation for our attitudes towards all beings, steering the mind towards acceptance and away from regret and ill-will.

The Ten Fetters
(Samyojana)

Self - belief (Sakkāya-ditthi)
Doubt (Vicikicchā), one of the 5 Hindrances)
Belief in rituals (Silabbata-parāmāsa)
Sensual Desire (Kāma-rāga), one of the 5H)
Ill will (Vyāpāda, one of the 5H)
Desire fo Existence with form (Rūpa-rāga)
Desire for Existence without form (Arūpa-rāga)
Conceit (Māna)
Restlessness (Uddhacca, one of the 5H)
Ignorance (Avijjā)

The Ten Fetters are deeply rooted habitual patterns that bind us to conditioned existence. They are overcome progressively as one advances through the four stages of realization.

Self-belief refers to believing that the self exists in some concrete way.
Doubt refers to doubt about the Buddha, the teaching, and training.
The third fetter refers to believing that rituals are effective in themselves.
Sensual desire means craving for sights, sounds, smells, tastes and contacts.
Ill - will is anger and negativity.
Desire for material existence is craving embodiment.
Desire for immaterial existence is craving disembodiment.
Conceit refers to measuring a sense of self through comparison.
Restlessness is a symptom of an unsatisfied, still-seeking mind.
Ignorance is not realizing the Three Characteristics in relation to all existence, the same delusion (moha) that had us entangled in the first place.

The Four Stages of Realization

Stream-Entry	(Sotāpanna)
Once Returner	(Sakadāgami)
Non-Returner	(Anāgami)
Fully Liberated	(Arahant)

One who has overcome the first three fetters has reached the first stage of realization called stream - entry. One has entered the stream leading to liberation and is assured of success in no more than seven lifetimes. At the 2nd stage of realization, the 4th and 5th fetters are overcome in their grosser forms. One is now called a Once - Returner, achieving success with only one more material existence. One who has fully dissolved the first five fetters has reached the 3rd stage of realization called Non - Returner. Such a one will achieve final liberation without being reborn. Being freed from all ten fetters, one realizes the 4th stage of realization, complete freedom and liberation in this life. Such a one is called Fully Liberated, a Holy One (Arahant).

The Wheel Of Buddhist Terms

The Three Characteristics, The Three Unwholesome Roots and
The Five Aggregates are the facts of our human existence.

The Four Noble Truths and Dependent Co-Arising are seeing
those facts in terms of the possibility of liberation.

The Noble Eightfold Path and The Four Foundations of Mindfulness
describe the practical path to be followed to realize that liberation.

The Thirty Seven Requisites of Enlightenment are a restatement of the essential factors of the path.

The Ten Perfections are qualities that support the practice and benefits others.

The Four Divine Abodes are developed as beneficial emotional responses to experience.

The Ten Fetters are the attachments that perpetuate our delusion and The Four Stages of Realization are the progressive eradication of those patterns that prevent the realization of liberation.

All of the teachings of the Buddha can be summed up in the phrase "Nothing whatsoever should be clung to as 'me' or 'mine'". All of the teachings exist to serve this goal, to aid in this realization, by either describing the situation or providing a skillful means to train oneself. "To cling to nothing" is a guide to proper relationship to experience, as well as a statement of the way things are when the goal is reached.

Each subject (or ring) has its own color and block of text. Some ring segments have another color lining the inside. This refers you to the ring of that color for more detail or a related subject. A lining with a numeral in the corner refers you to that individual segment of the ring of that color.

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